traditionally and whether there are indeed takeaways for the Indian side.

Looking back at seven decades of engagement, it would be fair to state that India has essentially taken a bilateral approach in respect of outstanding issues with China. There are many reasons for this, including a sense of Asian solidarity and a suspicion of third-party interests that emanated from other experiences. Brief exceptions to this are mostly in circumstances when PM Nehru was compelled to turn to the US and UK after Bomdila fell to the People's Liberation Army (PLA) in 1962. To some extent, the post-1971 relationship with the USSR also encouraged India to look at its relationship with China in the larger global context. But these were not lasting, and after 1988, India reverted to the earlier tradition of engagement without leveraging. Underlying this narrow view was also a belief that problems between the two countries were resolvable in the near term.

On its part, India has been remarkably consistent and steady in its approach to the resolution of differences, including on the boundary question. As a result, Indians have generally been less contextualized in their approach and do not readily correlate the relationship with developments in larger world politics. There was neither an inclination to practise balance of power nor indeed an appetite for using opportunities presented by international developments. Nehru's own excessive caution in 1962 was one illustration of this belief. In fact, Indian policy in the past has exhibited such a degree of self-restraint that it led inadvertently to the expectation that others can have influence, if not a veto, over its choices. That era, too, ended in 2014.

The Chinese approach to India has been quite contrasting. While there have undoubtedly been sentiments of Asian commonness expressed from time to time, these have not obfuscated time-tested approaches to dealing with neighbours. So much so that Pakistan's membership of Western military alliances was overlooked by China in the 1950–60s as part of a balancing strategy. A decade later, this was taken to higher levels through nuclear and missile collaboration that specifically targeted India. When it comes to bilateral negotiations, China has focussed on differentials rather than on maintaining the logic of its positions. There have been radical shifts in its stance, especially in regard to its claims and priorities on the boundary question.

Overall, it can be asserted that in keeping with its fundamental world view, contemporary China has treated its relationship with India as a subset